Research on the Construction of a Digital Narrative Model for Chinese Historical Classics

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Introduction

Chinese historical classics, situated within the History (Shi) category of the traditional bibliographic system Jing, Shi, Zi, Ji (Classics, History, Philosophy, and Literature), embody rich narrative traditions shaped by classical historiography. However, their linear and static formats fall short of digital-era expectations for interactivity, flexibility, and personalization.

This study introduces a digital narrative model specifically designed for these texts. Drawing on digital narratology and Chinese historiographical principles, it analyzes narrative elements, structural formats, and interaction design. The model proposes flexible narrative pathways that address diverse user needs, offering a novel framework for digitally restructuring and engaging with historical knowledge.

Digital Narrative Models

A range of influential models inform the field of digital narratology. Ryan (2014) outlines multiple navigational forms—networks, vectors with side-branches, sea-anemone shapes, and mazes—supporting diverse plot curves. Carstensdottir et al. (2017) emphasize user interaction in game-based narratives via linear, branching, foldback, broom, and opportunistic structures. Koenitz et al. (2018) challenge Western-centric assumptions by incorporating non-Western narrative forms, such as etiological oral accounts and religious epics. Millard et al. (2013) propose a spatial model using metaphors like canyons, deltas, and plains to guide reader navigation. Basaraba (2018) highlights the feedback loop between creators and audiences in interactive digital narratives (IDNs) within cultural heritage contexts.

Digital Narrative Model for Chinese Historical Classics

In this model, the role of “narrator” is expanded to include both the historical author and the digital narrative designer. On the recipient side, narratees are divided into two main groups: professional researchers and the general public. These roles and relationships give rise to four narrative pathways: single-path, comparative, exploratory, and generative. Figure 1 illustrates the core structure of the model.

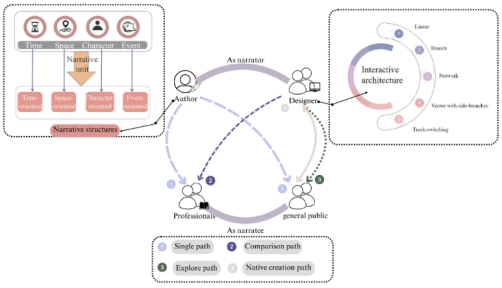

Figure 1: Model Diagram

The following sections will analyze and interpret each component of the model in detail.

Narratives units and structure

As a vital component of China’s cultural heritage, historical classics exhibit unique narrative traditions shaped by longstanding historiographical practices. Their narrative construction centers on four fundamental elements: time, space, character, and event. Each corresponds to a classical Chinese historiographic format: bian nian ti (Annals), guo bie ti (Regional Chronicles), ji zhuan ti (Biographies), and jishi benmo ti (Event-based Narratives). This study analyzes the structural features and constituent units of each, laying the groundwork for a digital model tailored to historical texts.

Interactive architecture

Interactivity distinguishes digital narratives from traditional forms, placing interaction design at the heart of the user experience (Carstensdottir et al. 2019). Building on established models, this study integrates interactive structures with the narrative features of Chinese historical classics.

The model incorporates five types of interactive architecture:

Linear: A single, fixed path where narrative elements unfold sequentially (Carstensdottir et al. 2017).

Branching: A tree-like structure that enables divergent narrative paths based on user decisions.

Network: A loop-enabled format where choices influence narrative progression.

Vector with Side-Branches: A forward-moving path with optional digressions to supplementary content (Ryan 2014).

Track-Switching: Allows movement across different narrative threads at defined nodes, mirroring the four classical narrative structures.

This framework, designed by the narrative architect, is adapted based on content, user needs, and the desired balance of coherence and flexibility.

Multidimensional Narrative Pathways

Digital narrative scholarship increasingly prioritizes user-centered design, emphasizing the narratee's role in shaping narrative progression. In the proposed model, narratees are grouped into professional researchers and the general public. To meet their differing needs, the model defines four narrative pathways:

Single-path Narrative: A fixed structure authored by the original historian, uniformly addressing all users.

Comparative Narrative: Designed for scholarly use, juxtaposes multiple elements for analytical comparison.

Exploratory Narrative: Offers nonlinear, cross-linked content for personalized, associative exploration.

Generative Narrative: Goes beyond the original text via creative expansion. Through technologies like AI and VR, designers and users co-create immersive, participatory narratives.

Together, these narrative modes foster flexible engagement with historical texts, aligned with diverse user intents and interactive preferences.

Conclusion

The proposed digital narrative model offers a conceptual foundation for reimagining Chinese historical classics in digital contexts. It supports deeper content exploration, enriches public cultural engagement, and opens new directions for digital humanities scholarship. While still theoretical, future work will focus on implementation, empirical evaluation, and iterative refinement.

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